

The Flavors of

The Middle East and Africa

Mention the Middle East in a culinary context and most people think of kebabs and kofte. In fact, the region's cuisine is as rich, colorful, and ancient as its history. The region is also renowned for its hospitality, where "a guest is a gift from God"; travelers often find themselves invited to sample dishes where they taste best: in the home. In contrast to the Middle East's homogenous approach, Africa's 61 territories have enormously varied cuisines, offering surprising delights.

Mesopotamia, as it was known in ancient times, is called the "Cradle of Civilization," and it was here, around 7,000 years ago, that man first turned from nomadic hunter-gatherer into settled farmer. Part of a wider region known as the "Fertile Crescent," which stretched sicklelike from North Africa's Nile along the Mediterranean coast all the way to the Persian Gulf, this was the home of the Biblical Garden of Eden, and it was long known as the "land of milk and honey."

It was the region's abundance of food and, in particular, wheat that first caught the covetous eye of the Romans, who occupied the

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area in the 2nd century AD. Hot on the heels of the Romans came other powers who introduced their own culinary traditions but also adopted the local ones. Later, they carried this culinary combination with them as

they swept east or west, bequeathing the whole region an unusual culinary homogeneity. Like the magnificent ancient monuments of the Middle East, its foods are a legacy of the powers that passed through it. With the Arabs in the 7th century came dates and nuts as well as exotic spices from seafaring merchants, bringing turmeric, cardamom, cumin, peppercorns, cloves, and allspice from India and Southeast Asia. With the Mongols came dumplings

and the roasting of meat on fires – the world's first kebabs. The Persians brought rice and poultry, sometimes combining both into such sumptuous dishes as *khoresh-e fesejan* and *polo*. The Ottomans introduced the fine art of sweet and savory pastry, conspiring to make such delectable delicacies as baklava, as well as the tradition of meze – dining on little dishes such as falafel and *kibbeh nayyeh* – and the fashion for drinking coffee.

The Phenomenon of the Souk

Nowhere are the region's riches more evident than in the souks, each one a labyrinthine warren of stands selling the finest local goods and produce. There's rice and waxy saffron from the Caspian Sea, honey-sweet soft fruits including translucent apricots from Lebanon, plump cherries, quinces, and melons from Iran, fragrant figs from Turkey, and beautiful artichokes, peppers, okra, zucchini,

Right Pomegranate on sale in Iran, where it has long played a key role in the cuisine
Below Women selling the daily catch of sardines on a beach in Maputo, Mozambique

